

# **Defensive V Offensive? How Do We Balance The Needs Of The Many – Black hat USA 2026**



# Three Things

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➤ | How is the UK  
responding to  
cyber  
proliferation?

➤ | What is the NCF's  
use of industry  
strategy?

➤ | How you can  
help us?



# MISSION

*Balancing Defensive and Offensive Cyber Capabilities*

## KING

*Mission Outcomes*



## QUEEN

*National Cyber Power*



## ROOKS

*Platforms & Infrastructure*



## BISHOPS

*Intelligence & Insight*



## KNIGHTS

*Specialist Operations*



## PAWNS

*The Ecosystem*



# whoami

Annie

# whoami

Dave

# whoami

Clare

# **why are we here?**

...

# Verbage

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➤ | Commercial cyber intrusion Capabilities – CCIC

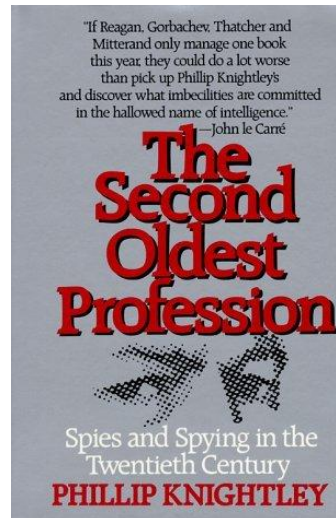
➤ | Pall Mall Process – PMP

➤ | Responsible Cyber Power in Practice – RCPIP

# Context

How we got here

# The Preserve of Government



● This article is more than 16 years old

## US appoints first cyber warfare general

Pentagon creates specialist online unit to counter cyber attack amid growing fears of militarisation of the internet



📷 The Pentagon is channelling a growing volume of troops and resources into countering cyber warfare. Photograph: Mike Nelson/AFP/Getty Images

INFORMATION

## Investigatory Powers Act

GCHQ's mission is predominantly governed by the Investigatory Powers Act 2016



On Tuesday 29 November 2016, the [Investigatory Powers Bill](#) received Royal Assent and became known as the Investigatory Powers Act 2016. It provides a new framework to govern the use and oversight of investigatory powers by law enforcement and the security and intelligence agencies.

# Offensive Eco-system: a long road

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➤ | Everyone is on a [shared] journey

# Early Market



EDITORS' PICK

## Meet Paragon: An American-Funded, Super-Secretive Israeli Surveillance Startup That 'Hacks WhatsApp And Signal'

By [Thomas Brewster](#), Forbes Staff. Senior writer at Forbes covering cybercri...

[Follow Author](#)

Published Jul 29, 2021, 12:30pm EDT, Updated Jul 30, 2021, 06:58am EDT



EDITORS' PICK | INNOVATION > CYBERSECURITY

## A Multimillionaire Surveillance Dealer Steps Out Of The Shadows . . . And His \$9 Million WhatsApp Hacking Van

By [Thomas Brewster](#), Forbes Staff. Senior writer at Forbes covering cybercrim...

[Follow Author](#)

Published Aug 05, 2019, 10:01am EDT, Updated Mar 09, 2020, 09:45am EDT

The Big Read Cyber Security [+ Add to myFT](#)

## Israel's NSO: the business of spying on your iPhone

Software that has hacked WhatsApp has also been accused of helping governments spy on dissidents



NSO's Pegasus software can allegedly penetrate any iPhone via one simple missed call on WhatsApp

Cyprus

This article is more than 6 years old

## Cyprus police arrest three in Israeli-owned 'spy van' investigation

High-tech surveillance van allegedly used to intercept phones and messaging apps



The van could reportedly intercept WhatsApp messages from a distance of a kilometre. Photograph: Anadolu Agency/Anadolu Agency via Getty Images

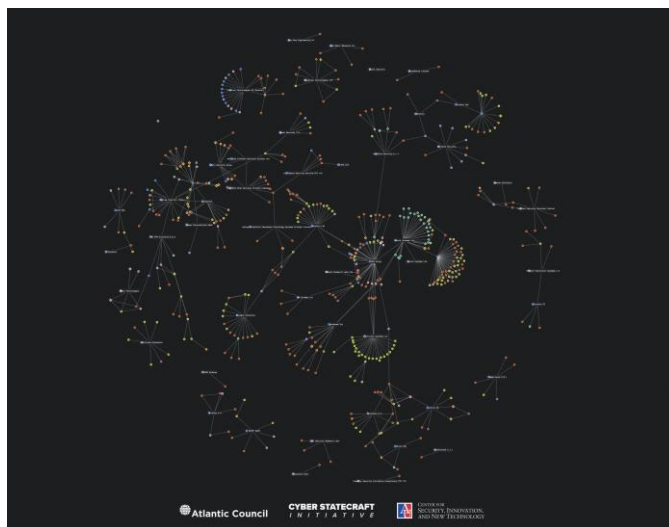
# Evolving landscapes

Cybersecurity

Report | September 4, 2024

## Mythical Beasts and where to find them: Mapping the global spyware market and its threats to national security and human rights

By Jen Roberts, Trey Herr, Nitansha Bansal, and Nancy Messieh, with Emma Taylor, Jean Le Roux, and Sopo Gelava



GlobalData.

## RED Lattice acquires Israeli spyware company Paragon for \$500m



As part of the deal - Verdict

RESEARCH → TARGETED SURVEILLANCE

## Espionage Against the European Parliament

Member of Committee Investigating Spyware Hacked with Pegasus

# Offensive Eco-system: growth

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- | In 2023 we assessed that 80 countries had purchased commercial cyber intrusion capabilities, and now it's over 100 countries

# Developing threat landscape

## Google patches worrying Chrome zero-day flaw being exploited in the wild - here's how to stay safe

**News** By Sead Fadilpašić | Published 19 November 2025

A bug in Google Chrome V8 allowed for arbitrary code execution

Home > Tech

### iPhone exploit DarkSword has been released in the wild: How to protect yourself

Uh-oh. Now anyone can easily use it.

By [Matt Binder](#) on March 24, 2026 [f](#) [X](#) [v](#)

GOVERNMENT

## Ex-L3Harris executive sentenced to 87 months in prison for selling zero-day exploits to Russian broker

Additionally, the U.S. Treasury sanctioned the Russian zero-day brokerage that Peter Williams sold the exploits to.

BY [GREG OTTO](#) • FEBRUARY 24, 2026

[Listen to this article](#) 2:27 [Learn more.](#)

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## Canadian iPhone hacking firm sues ex-worker over alleged theft of secrets

[Magnet Forensics](#) filed a lawsuit against Mario Del Gaudio and Paradigm Shift Technology, alleging the flaw was publicly disclosed on the company's blog



Bloomberg News  
Patrick Howell O'Neill

Published Jul 20, 2026 Last updated 6 days ago 2 minute read [Join the conversation](#)

# Response

What are the UK and others doing

# Offensive Eco-system: balance

News story

## UK and France seek views on commercial cyber intrusion industry practices

The UK and France are launching this private consultation under the Pall Mall Process, an international and multistakeholder initiative to stop the threat posed by the proliferation and irresponsible use of commercial cyber intrusion capabilities.

From: [Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office](#)

Published: 20 November 2025

Last updated: 29 January 2026 — [See all updates](#)

BLOG POST

## What makes a responsible cyber actor: introducing the Pall Mall industry consultation on good practice

Calling vulnerability researchers, exploit developers and others in the offensive cyber industry to share their views.

Policy paper

## The Pall Mall Process Code of Practice for States

Updated 23 October 2025

# Offensive Eco-system: balance

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## Coruna: Inside the Nation-State-Grade iOS Exploit Kit We've Been Tracking



Matthias Frielingsdorf · Published Mar 3, 2026

### Google and Amnesty International teamed up to make it harder for spyware vendors to hide

Intrusion Logging marks the first feature from a major device vendor to aid with forensic detection of sophisticated threats, Amnesty International said.

BY TIM STARKS • MAY 12, 2026

# The Equities Process

This article describes the Equities Process operated on behalf of the Government by GCHQ. The Equities Process is the means through which decisions are taken on the handling of vulnerabilities found in technology to achieve the best overall outcome in the interests of the United Kingdom

## The process

The following entities are involved in the decision-making process:

1. The Equities Technical Panel (ETP), made up of a panel of subject matter experts from across the UK Intelligence Community including the NCSC.
2. The GCHQ Equity Board (EB), which includes representation from other Government agencies and Departments as required. The Chair of the Equity Board is a senior civil servant with appropriate experience and expertise, usually drawn from the NCSC, and answerable in this role to the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the NCSC.
3. The Equities Oversight Committee, chaired by the CEO of the NCSC, which ensures the Equities Process is working appropriately and in accordance with specified procedures. This Committee also advises the CEO of the NCSC on equity decisions escalated from the Equity Board.

<https://www.gchq.gov.uk/information/equities-process>

# Offensive Eco-system: approach

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➤ | NCSC is a cyber security organization ...

... we need know the capabilities that other parts of HMG have to manage risk

... origin, other users/customers, proliferation management and defensive options

# When it goes adverse

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- | Know your supply chain, customer ... and your employer
  - ... or there is the potential for ending up in the plot of Sneakers

# Objective

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- | **Impose significant asymmetric cost on adversaries**  
**via technology, architecture, operations, personal accountability etc.**

# Objective

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➤ | **Demonstrate responsible**

**via Pall Mall process, accountability, precision, calibration, oversight  
& transparency**

# Offensive Eco-system: State Tools

## Prohibition on Use by the United States Government of Commercial Spyware That Poses Risks to National Security

A Presidential Document by the Executive Office of the President on 03/30/2023

News story

## UK clamps down on China-based companies for reckless and irresponsible activity in cyberspace

Two tech companies based in China have been sanctioned for reckless and indiscriminate cyberattacks

## Levers of Government

PRESS RELEASE

## Former General Manager for U.S. Defense Contractor Sentenced to 87 Months for Selling Stolen Trade Secrets to Russian Broker

Tuesday, February 24, 2026

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For Immediate Release

Office of Public Affairs

★ ★ ★

## Announcement of a Visa Restriction Policy to Promote Accountability for the Misuse of Commercial Spyware

PRESS STATEMENT

ANTONY J. BLINKEN, SECRETARY OF STATE

FEBRUARY 5, 2024

# Offensive Eco-system: approach

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➤ | UK strategy is to bifurcate

... define responsible

... support responsible

... thus making irresponsible a more tractable problem to deny, degrade and disrupt

# Offensive Eco-system: finding the right balance



## The National Cyber Force: Responsible Cyber Power in Practice



## UK Cyber Effects Network

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## About

The UK Cyber Effects Network seeks to build and strengthen a UK community of interest that fosters informed debate around the theory and practice of offensive cyber and other cyber effects operations.

# Offensive Eco-system

➤ | Who are the responsible actors to engage with?



# Pathways for talent

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## ➤ | Ensuring our talent pools have roles

... creating an eco-system where researchers can choose to work for high reputation firms

... this will be very important in the near term as we navigate the AI correction



# How we achieve mutual objectives

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- | We need to create the operating environment to allow responsible industry to thrive



# How we achieve mutual objectives

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**➤ | We collectively need to be evidence based in decision making**

# How we achieve mutual objectives

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➤ | Countries developing and discussing VR strategies

# How we achieve mutual objectives

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➤ | Ensuring we maintain a skilled workforce after AI with future talent

# Closing out

...

# Closing out

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➤ | There is a risk of the binary debate

# Closing out

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➤ | World is in reality grey

# Closing out

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➤ | Defence is done  
with and through  
a high caliber  
responsible  
offence

➤ | We all need a  
functioning and  
aligned market to  
exist”

➤ | There is a shared  
endeavor to  
make this a  
reality

# Closing out

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➤ | We need to work in partnership to get the outcomes we seek...

# Closing out

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- | **With AI**  
**We are entering a period of high disruption for offensive and defense**

# Closing

➤ | Thank you!

- Annie
- Dave
- Clare

